Hell Box

Symptoms of the bends: Joint pain, swelling, fatigue, difficulty breathing, nausea, headaches, chest pain, itching, rash, and pain and numbness in the limbs. If not treated, the bends can be fatal.

I'm not sure what I did with my life that led me to underwater welding under an oil rig hundreds of miles from dry land. Maybe it was getting my welding certification with high marks, or listening to my scuba diving instructor and trying out the underwater welding program. I think it's more likely that it was telling Oscar, "I'll take the job," like a dumbass, and getting on the helicopter that took me to this fish-smelling dump.

I reach up my hand and slap my face, rubbing my left eye with the palm of my hand. A groan escapes me as I sit up in my bed and swing my legs to the floor. My thick wool socks manage to protect my feet from the frigid cold for the most part, but some stray strands manage to slither through and bite at my skin. I shiver and quickly turn on the heater by my feet, wanting to enjoy the heat while I've got it. I drag my feet to the bathroom, reluctantly leaving the heater to warm the room in my absence.

I rub my eyes, examining my tired face in the mirror. My copper-colored beard has grown, cause that's what hair does. I relieve my bladder of its burden and I brush my teeth with a mint toothpaste so powerful it could wake a coma patient. No shower today, I'll do that after I'm out of the water. I hear voices walk past my room as I shuffle back to the heater, nearly tripping over that stupid folded rug. I gotta throw that thing away, or give it to Greg. He likes tacky stuff like that.

“Damn that Oscar, he wouldn’t part from a penny even if it meant it would save a man. Investing in taking care of this hell bucket isn’t a bad idea,” I don’t recognize the voice, nor am I paying enough attention to care to hear. I quickly strip down to my boxers and throw on my dry diving suit as fast as I can. I think I’m finally getting used to the cold of this metal box I live on. My mind wanders back to the voices outside, curiosity plucking at my brain as I lean toward the door to listen in. Why the hell not. “The risk of blowouts is increasing by the day, our electricity is fucked, and the whole damn rig is falling apart! I’m telling you, one of these days the rig is gonna go down in flames…” The voices drift off. Leaving my mind reeling. Well, that’s fucking great, so comforting. I love that I’m gonna be under this box of junk in a few hours.

Once I get my dry diving suit on I turn off my heater. Sighing, I take a moment to look at the pictures hung up over my desk where my journal sits. I don’t have kids, they’re too much work and responsibility. Especially with the job I have, it wouldn’t be fair to my husband to leave him alone to take care of crazy screaming demon spawns for months on end. So we got a dog instead, her name is Wawa and we adore her. My favorite picture is of my husband, Kyle, hugging her with that big goofy smile he gets on his face that makes his eyes crinkle at the sides. I smile, delicately taking the picture to admire it for just another moment before I let it go and turn towards the door. I trudge out of my small room and into the hallway, making my way towards the cafeteria to grab some grub.

I take a deep breath, peering into the crashing waves beneath me. Time for another twelve hours under the hateful waves, maybe even more with all the damages Sam told me about. Smart woman, but she’s got intense eyes.

“Yah ready Bendt?” Arthur questions me, his hands on his hips. I can hear him clear as rain through the intercom in my helmet. I respond by leaping into the waves below with a bird in

the air. “Thanks, asshole,” I hear him chuckle through the radio. The waves wrap their arms around me, embracing me in her ever so familiar frigid embrace. I swim forward, my underwater stinger securely in my belt. I secure myself to the large metal post, double and triple checking before I grab out my stinger and start my work. It’s easy to fall into a pattern down here. Checking your gear, making sure gas levels are fine, welding, swimming, repeat. Hours go by like wind passing through leaves, only occasionally interrupted by Arthur checking up on me.

“So, you get to go in three months for Christmas yah?” I ask Arthur, able to double task talking to him and welding.

“Sure do! I’m gonna be able teh see mah wee ones, you know, Abi and Ella. I’ve missed ehm more than I can say.” Arthur says, and I can just imagine his crooked-toothed smile and the gap in his teeth where a molar is missing. I laugh at the thought. “What you laughn’ at me for?” Arthur interrogates with an entertained snort.

“Nothing mate, nothin. Just happy for you. I’m sure your girls are excited for you home.” I say in reply.

“Oh they are, I got a letter bout a week ago. They might miss me more than I miss ehm,” I can sense the sadness in his voice, and I pause my welding for a second.

“I doubt it. Don’t you worry Arthur, you’ll see your girls in no time.”

“Ei, you’re right. Time flies if you're having fun!” We both laugh at the irony of having fun on this floating hunk of metal. What a shit show.

I’m straddling a long metal post covered in barnacles, welding the base of a large iron post that needs to stay connected to the large metal tube I’m currently on. It reminds me of when I was just starting this job a few years back. I was so nervous, constantly checking to make sure everything was in line. I still do, but I’m more confident in my skills now and I trust the people

watching over me on dry land. I know this is a dangerous job, but as long as I keep a cool head, I'm sure I'll be alright. I think I'm about 400 feet down right now. I've been getting good at guessing.

I hear a loud roaring sound like a dragon screaming its rage to the world. I cling to the pole, praying the cords holding me to the oil rig hold as I feel the entire leg shake and groan. My heart starts to race, I can feel it thundering in my ears.

"Arthur? What the fuck is going on up there?" I shout through my coms, struggling with the iron cord holding me to the violently shaking Oil rig. "Arthur! You dickhead are you alright? Was there an explosion?" I get myself free, distress blinding my judgment as I start to swim up. I hear crackling over the intercom before relief floods me when I hear Arthur's voice. But that relief is gone quickly.

"Bendt! There's been an explosion, the rig is on fire! There's been a blowout!" I hear people screaming around him, and a loud boom.

"Holly shit! Arthur, I'm coming up," I say, kicking my finned feet facing the surface.

"Bendt, Bendt slow down, you need to come up slowly so you don't get the bends and kick the fish bucket- shit!" there's static again.

"Arthur? Arthur! Fuck!" I swim a little further before stopping and hooking myself to the eerily still rig. The quiet has never bothered me before, but now it feels dangerous. I can't move too fast or I'll get the bends, but I don't know how fast or slow that is. I probably should, but my mind is reeling with panic. If there was a blowout, then the whole rig could be up in flames and go down at any second. I hope they're all getting on escape boats or the helicopter. But most of all I hope they don't forget me down here!

It starts to get hard to breathe. It doesn't start all at once, but over time I start to gasp for air like a water-starved fish. Fuck.

"Arthur, Arthur I can't breathe, what's going on?" I say through gasps, panic gripping at me as I struggle for air. Did something happen to the cords connecting me to the boats? Is this how I am going to die? I wheeze for air, scrambling to attach myself to the rig and grab onto a metal beam with my legs. I twist and turn on the airflow from my emergency air tanks, and off the air from the air on the boat. I gasp, coughing as I suck in the mixture of oxygen and helium. These tanks won't last me long, I need to get up to the surface and hope. I look up to the distant sun. Wait… No, I think that's fire. The water is on fucking fire. I scratch my arms.

I trust my muscle memory as I swim my way up, the sounds from above reaching me before I see anything. Large booms and faint roars of metal against metal reach me, and tremors run down the legs of the large metal structure. I kick harder, following the metal legs up through the pitch-black toward the surface. The lights on my head barely cut through the thick layer of oil and darkness. My heart thunders through my chest, louder in my ears than the explosions above.

I break through the surface, and I'm blinded by the light of fire. I shout with surprise, ducking back under the water to avoid the fire. My breathing quickens, fear clouding my vision as my brain is clogged up by questions. What happened to Arthur? Is this how I die? I need to get out of the water, my legs ache from swimming without assistance and my head is pounding. I climb out of the water using a ladder, scrambling up as fast as I can in the extremely heavy, soaking-wet diving suit. I collapse onto a metal platform, trying to scratch my arms through the suit, but it's no use. All I can see is smoke and oil, and all I hear is the crackling of fire. No, wait. There's something else I can see. There's a soaking wet and burned figure, three meters or so

away from me. I squint my eyes through the smoke, breathing heavily. Damn it, I feel like I'm going to throw up.

I crawl forward, dragging the heavy diving suit with me. I reach the figure, who looks like they're breathing. I turn them over and gasp as I see the burned face of Arthur. He's unconscious, but I think he's breathing. But with all this smoke and gas, he won't be for long.

The itching gets worse, it feels like spiders are crawling all over me and biting at my skin. My legs hurt so bad, and it feels like there's a weight on my chest. Then realization hits me. I look down at Arthur, and then the oxygen tanks on my back. I groan,

"No… oh fuck, oh fuck, Kyle I'm sorry," I whimper like a wounded animal as I start to take off my diving suit. I have to cut some of it off using my diving knife because my body starts to swell larger than it was before. Arthur opens his eyes, a pained grimace on his face. He looks at me as I take off my helmet and quickly place it on him. My lungs are assaulted by smoke and gas and the smell of oil and burning skin, causing me to hack and choke on the thick smoke full of chemicals. I turn on the oxygen to his helmet, and his face falls. He tries to say something, but I can't hear him. My ears are ringing and my throat burns, but I force a smile at him as I desperately scratch at my marble-looking skin. I feel dizzy. My mind calms a bit, though, as my decision is made up.

"Say hi to your girls Arthur… and please, tell Kyle I'm sorry."

Everything goes dark.